

Grassroot Research Institute for Policy (GRIP)

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Research that begins where policy lands

The distance at the heart of governance

Every policy has two addresses. It is written at one, a ministry, a university department, a conference hall in the capital and it must live at another: a village ration shop, a classroom without a teacher, a city pavement where a street vendor works past midnight. Modern policymaking has grown remarkably sophisticated about the first address and remains almost blind to the second.

Consider how evidence typically reaches policymakers. It reaches through national datasets, administrative records, model-based projections, and interviews with officials and “key informants”. Almost none of it is generated with the people policies are meant for. That being said, communities appear in research as respondents or as mere data points almost never as authors of knowledge or the voice that matters.

The consequences are predictable. The average became a hiding place for reality; a national statistic could go up while whole regions went down. Failures were not in the planning but in the execution; that is where the program meets the ground truth of how local labour markets, social stratification, and logistics function. By the time the failure made its way into a report, the cost in time and money had already been borne. Failure had been obvious long before then; on the ground, to those who lived it.

Credibility demands candor. The “grassroots” do not constitute a single perspective. They present perspective based on realities known to a landlord and a landless peasant in the same village are different, and GRIP needs to purposefully include the diverse voices of class, caste, gender, and age in order to avoid giving undue weight to local power. The understand that locals have is profound but not perfect as regards causes, and the needs to be supplemented by scientific analysis rather than mythologized as an alternative to it. But there is also the problem of being used, of being quoted selectively.

Why a New Institute and Why Now

Policy research is already done in universities and think tanks, but this is an inherently elitist exercise which is concentrated in capitals, often reliant on secondary data, and incentivized by

publication not impact on anyone's life. Even "evidence-based policy making" involves gathering evidence from communities', and then analyzing it somewhere else.

It is imperative at this point in time due to the way in which commitments are now being made. The global commitments that range from "leaving no one behind" in the sustainable development goals to adaptation efforts all require highly detailed, granular, local data which simply is not available through official statistics. Decentralization has generated a multitude of local governments eager to be researched and serviced by none. People are losing faith in government institutions in USA, South America, Africa, India etc.... This precisely is because of the fact that they have never been listening to conversation of people that matter. As decisions are made more quickly due to technological changes, the gap becomes harder and harder to measure.

GRIP will address this problem at grass root level. So, that governments get a grip on the finances and development goals to streamline tax funds to where they matter most.

Each of the examples below has followed the same pattern: the introduction of a policy grounded on abstract reasoning, subsequent enforcement, fiscal rectitude, economic development or economic shock runs into a real situation that its planners did not take the time to investigate. In each of these examples, those directly affected knew about the damage, warned of it, but were ignored. The truth was finally revealed but only after journalists, lawyers, academics or large-scale protests forced the issue out in open for discussion.

[The Sick-Leave Blockade \(Sen. McConnell's Senate\)](#)

What it was: The United States remains the only wealthy nation without guaranteed national paid sick leave. As majority leader, McConnell repeatedly declined to bring sick-leave mandates to the Senate floor; in March 2020, the Senate under him stripped the House's emergency paid-sick-leave bill of its universal coverage (exempting large employers and many small ones) and set it to expire that December 31 after which extension attempts died. Ironically, recently he spent 3 months sick, yet he collected tax payer's money as salary.

Ground reality: Roughly a quarter of private-sector workers disproportionately low-waged food-service and care workers had no paid sick leave during a respiratory pandemic. Studies of states and cities that did mandate it found measurably lower disease spread. The unmeasured cost of "presenteeism", sick workers handling food and caring for the elderly because they could not afford a day off

GRIP lesson: this is the politics of inaction harm by omission, which official evaluation never captures because nothing was passed to evaluate. A standing "cost of inaction" audit and testimony channel would have put documented human costs into the Senate record every time a bill was blocked.

Flint, Michigan (2014-15)

What it was: A state-appointed emergency manager, under a fiscal-austerity law, switched Flint's water source to untreated Flint River to save money.

Ground reality: Residents complained about color, odor and illness for eighteen months while officials dismissed them and published misleading lead reading. The truth broke only through citizen science when a resident LeeAnne Walters collecting water samples with an independent engineer, and pediatrician tracing rising blood-lead levels in children

GRIP lesson: the ground truth existed in full, early and locally obtained data and was overridden by official data. Where the community can interrogate the dataset itself, lay knowledge beats the ministry. Community validated water, health and environmental monitoring is a core GRIP function

India

Demonetisation (2016)

What it was: Withdrawal of 86% of currency by value with four hours' notice, to strike at black money.

Ground reality: Nine in ten Indian workers operate in a cash economy. Small traders, daily wagers, and migrants faced queue deaths (over a hundred reported), broken supply chains, and demand collage while 99.3% of the invalidated notes eventually returned to the banks, undercutting the stated objective.

GRIP lesson: A one-week "delivery audit" walking through what a note ban does where bank branches' are sparse and small traders hold only high denomination cash would have predicted the actual mechanics. No such audit was done. It resulted in mass casualty of the poor lives.

CAA+NRC (2019)

What it was: The CAA fast tracks citizenship for undocumented migrants of six religions from 3 neighboring countries excluding Muslims while a promised nation-wide National Register of Citizens would require documentation of citizenship from everyone

Ground reality: In Assam alone, roughly 1.9million people were excluded from the final 2019 list where disproportionately poor, landless, and women who never possessed birth documents, including Bengali-origin Hindus the CAA was supposedly designed to protect. Journalists documented a string of suicides among the excluded and "doubtful voters" many facing Foreigners Tribunals with no legal aid.

What it cost: Nationwide protests, Shaheen Bagh sit-ins, the February 2020 Delhi riots (53 dead) and multiple states refusing to implement NRC. Constitutional challenges to the CAA remain pending before the Supreme Court.

GRIP lesson: Assam was a live pilot, and its exclusion-error rate was a fact. A GRIP-style “exclusion audit” where sampling who actually possesses which documents, street by street would have converted anecdote into the decisive statistic before national rollout.

Three Farm Laws (2020-21)

What it was: Sweeping agricultural marketing reforms passed in Sep 2020 with minimal consultation, via ordinance and voice vote, bypassing committee scrutiny

Ground reality: Farmers particularly in Punjab, with deep institutional memory of guaranteed procurement foresaw the erosion of MSP-backed mandis, asymmetric contract farming, and hoarding deregulation. Their objection was specific, informed and economic, not merely sentimental

What it cost: A thirteen-month protest at Delhi’s borders; unions attributed hundreds of deaths to the sit-in; the Supreme Court stayed the laws in Jan 2021. Repealed in full by Nov 2021

GRIP lesson: the farmer’s analysis was available before passage to anyone who asked. A pre-legislative reality audit, or pilot ground-truthing in two districts would have surfaced the objects at a fraction of the eventual cost.

The Rockefeller Drug Laws (1973-2009)

What it was: Governor Nelson Rockefeller’s response to a heroin panic, where a mandatory minimum sentences of 15 year to life for possession or sale of defined quantities, which was intended to crush “drug kingpins”

Ground reality: the kingpins (Italian mafia) had information to trade and lawyers to bargain with; the couriers, addicts, and teenagers did the mandatory years. Sentences fell overwhelmingly on Black and Latino New Yorkers, though drug use is roughly even across races. Whole blocks lost a generation of young men. A systematic upstate prison towns counted them as census “residents” who could not vote.

How it ended: Piecemeal reforms in 2004-05; the 2009 repeal of most mandatory minimum allowed roughly 1500 prisoners to be resentenced nearly after 3 decades of abuse.

GRIP lesson: the gap between design intent (“kingpins”) and delivery reality was measurable in sentencing data within the first year, and in prison visiting rooms immediately. A delivery audit would have exposed it before it became a generational wound of economic apartheid sponsored by the state.

Stop-and-Frisk (NYPD, 2002-2013)

What it was: A proactive policing doctrine that peaked at 685000 street stops in 2011 roughly nine in ten involving young black and latino men, and 88% ending in no arrest or summons

Ground reality: Communities experienced it as a daily predation; a generation learned to avoid the police. Research suggest heavy stops eroded residents willingness to call 911 in the very neighbourhoods whose safety was the program’s state purpose. In *Floyd vs. City of New York* (2013), a federal court found the practice unconstitutional racial profiling; the stops fell 95% under court-ordered reform, and the predicted crime surge did not materialize (causation remains debated to this day).

GRIP lesson: the department’s metric (stops) and the ground’s outcome (legitimacy, cooperation) pointed in opposite directions for decades before a judge intervened. Community panels track the outcome the institution will not.

The Nursing Home Directive (2020)

What it was: A March 25, 2020 state health directive requiring nursing homes to readmit medically stable COVID-positive patients discharged from hospitals.

Ground reality: Administrators warned they lacked isolation capacity; families were locked out as deaths mounted. The AG’s January 2021 report found the state had excluded residents who died in hospitals, undercounting deaths by as much as half and a top aide admitted figures had been withheld amid a federal inquiry. A 2024 DOJ report later concluded the directive itself was not a major driver of deaths, so the causal questions remains contested to this day; the data-integrity problem is a documented fact.

GRIP lesson: The contested object was the count itself. A community validated registry of the dead, upon tallying with families record, validated against the official ones would have kept the record honest while it still mattered.

NYCHA's False Lead Inspection Certifications

(need to research)

- children were poisoned
- 1970s "planned shrinkage" in the south Bronx.

The Emergency Manager Laws (Michigan)

What it was: state-appointed emergency managers empowered to override mayors, councils and contracts in "fiscally stressed" jurisdictions. Voters repealed the law by referendum in Nov 2012; six weeks later, a lame-duck legislature re-enacted it with an appropriation rider making it referendum proof

Ground reality: it was applied exclusively to majority-Black cities at one point roughly half of Michigan's Black residents lived under governments they could not vote out. Residents organized, sued, and protested "taxation without representation". This law is the direct institutional root of the Flint water crisis

GRIP lesson: This policy removed the community's voice itself leaving no internal feedback channel at all. When the audit must come from outside the state, an independent standing institute is not a luxury but the system's only sensor.

Detroit Water Shutoffs (2014)

What it was: To recover arrears, the water department shut off service to ~30,000 households in 2014 alone, and well over 100,000 across the decade. UN human rights experts warned in 2014 that the campaign could violate international law.

Ground reality: In a city with ~40% poverty, shutoffs meant lost hygiene, disease risk, and documented cases of child-welfare referrals against families whose homes lacked water. Researchers linked shutoff zones to water-associated illness. While in the same state where Flint's water was poisoned. A COVID moratorium and income-based affordability plans followed only after years of pressure.

GRIP lesson: The billing system says "delinquent account closed"; the ground says "a child who cannot bathe." Ground-truthing administrative cutoffs against health outcomes is a core GRIP function.

PFAS Contamination — Kent County & Oscoda (2010s)

What it was: Wolverine Worldwide's tannery waste, dumped from the 1950s–90s, leached PFAS into hundreds of private drinking wells; at the former Wurtsmith Air Force Base, firefighting foam contaminated waters around Oscoda.

Ground reality: Oscoda residents had noticed foam on their creeks and pushed officials for years before state action. In the Rockford area, 2017 testing finally confirmed extreme PFAS levels in well water; Wolverine later settled for roughly \$70 million, and Michigan built some of the nation's strictest standards after the fact.

GRIP lesson: Contamination outran the official dataset by decades; lay observation was the early warning system, but had no standing. Community environmental monitoring gives that observation institutional weight.

The Nestlé Permit (2018)

What it was: Mid-Flint-crisis, the state approved Nestlé's request to increase groundwater pumping to 400 gallons per minute, for a \$200-per-year administrative fee; over residents' objections at hearings.

Ground reality: The same water, sold back to the same state's residents as bottled product.

GRIP lesson: The injustice is invisible in any single permit file; it appears only when auditing across cases — Flint's poison, Detroit's shutoffs, corporate pumping at \$200/year. GRIP's cross-case pattern audit is the instrument no ministry possesses.

Deregulation and Winter Storm Uri (2021)

What it was: The 1999 deregulation law built an isolated, market-only grid with no winterization mandate despite freeze-related failures in 1989, 2003, and 2011, and a federal post-mortem that explicitly recommended weatherization.

Ground reality: In February 2021, millions of households (over four million at peak) went dark in subfreezing temperatures. People died of hypothermia in their beds and of carbon monoxide from cars and grills brought indoors; Austin's outage maps showed cuts concentrated in Black and brown neighborhoods. The official death toll stands at 246; excess-mortality analysis by BuzzFeed News put the real figure near 700. Damage estimates ran to ~\$100 billion or more.

How it ended: Post-storm legislation mandated some weatherization — with enforcement gaps that a December 2022 near-miss exposed again.

GRIP lesson: The database versus the bedroom, again. An independent mortality registry — hospital logs, medical examiner records, family reports reconciled against the state count — is the difference between 246 and 700 dead. Counting the dead cannot be left to the entity with an interest in the smaller number.

[SB 8 and Its Aftermath \(2021\)](#)

What it was: A ban on abortion after roughly six weeks, enforced through \$10,000-plus private bounty suits deliberately structured to evade federal review — followed after Dobbs (2022) by a near-total ban.

Ground reality: Physicians reported that the law's "medical emergency" exceptions were legally unusable at the bedside, forcing dangerous delays in treating miscarriages and pregnancy complications; investigative reporting has documented maternal deaths following such delays, and thousands of women now travel out of state monthly. The state's rationale — protecting unborn life — is a moral claim evidence cannot adjudicate; the clinical delivery effects above are documented facts.

GRIP lesson: Any policy whose safety depends on exceptions needs a delivery audit of the exceptions: paper safety-valves versus emergency-room reality. A GRIP field station attached to hospital labor-and-delivery floors would produce exactly that record.

[Foster Care — M.D. v. Perry / United States v. Texas \(2011 \)](#)

What it was: Federal courts found Texas's foster care system unconstitutional: children warehoused overnight in state offices, placed in unlicensed facilities, and prescribed powerful psychotropic drug combinations without oversight.

Ground reality: Children sleeping in office buildings, moved without notice, abused in some placements — with caseworker loads that made supervision impossible. The state litigated against oversight for years; remedial orders continue today.

GRIP lesson: The affected population was the least able to be a "key informant." A longitudinal panel that follows children through placements — with their own testimony as they age — is the missing instrument for any system whose wards cannot petition it.

[Operation Lone Star \(2021\)](#)

What it was: A multi-billion-dollar deployment of state National Guard and troopers to the border, with razor wire, buoy barriers, and mass trespass arrests on private ranches — largely on charges later dropped.

Ground reality: In its 2024 Supreme Court filing, the Justice Department said Texas had blocked federal Border Patrol access to a park where a woman and two children drowned that same night; troopers' internal complaints described orders to push migrants, including children, back into the river. The state defends the operation as sovereign border protection — the point here is that state and federal narratives directly conflict.

GRIP lesson: Where two governments' accounts diverge, only contemporaneous, dual-validated ground documentation is credible to both. A field station's dated records are the only record neither side can dismiss as the other's spin.

Forced Sterilizations (Peru, 1996–2000)

What it was: A "family planning" program that sterilized well over 200,000 women (official registry; advocates say far more), overwhelmingly poor, indigenous, Quechua-speaking — many coerced or uninformed, some killed.

Ground reality: For some twenty years, the women's testimony was the only dataset. Prosecutors shelved cases in 2009 and 2014; grassroots groups (the Quipu testimony project wove each woman's account into knots of yarn) kept archives alive. In December 2021, the Supreme Court finally revived prosecution as crimes against humanity. It remains before the courts.

GRIP lesson: The registry gap at its purest — harm without a dataset is officially nonexistent. Community researchers documenting contemporaneously would have made this forensics in 1998 instead of 2021.

Cochabamba Water War (Bolivia, 1999–2000)

What it was: Under World Bank pressure, the city's water was privatized into a 40-year concession; rates jumped ~35%, and the new water law reportedly even required licenses for rainwater collection.

Ground reality: In a city of minimum-wage households, water bills approached a quarter of family income. Protest exploded; a state of siege was declared; a 17-year-old, Víctor Hugo Daza, was shot dead; and in April 2000 the concession was cancelled outright. The company's international arbitration claim was later dropped for a token payment. The struggle seeded the global movement that produced the UN's 2010 recognition of water as a human right.

GRIP lesson: A two-week participatory household-budget study before signing would have shown the tariff was unpayable. The affordability audit placed the policy prices against real ledgers which is perhaps GRIP's simplest, highest-yield instrument.

GRIP

Get a grip before you draft

A research institute that reverses the direction of evidence. Grass root level evidence directed policy design with measurable outcome and metrics that can be tracked by all stakeholders. Independent, Free and unbiased evidence collection for the stakeholders collective.

Our pillars

1. Field stations, not fly-in-surveys: Small resident research teams based in districts and neighborhoods for years, watching how policies actually unfold across seasons, elections, and shocks.
2. Community researchers: Local youth, women, farmers, and informal workers trained and paid as researchers and credited as co-investigators who help transform while building local capability.
3. Methodological toolkit: Participatory action research, longitudinal community panels, citizen-generated data, community score cards, oral testimony, and ground-truthing of official statistics which are paired with quantitative discipline so findings carry weight.
4. Double validation : Every finding passes academic peer review and community validation. It returns to the people it describes before it is published.
5. Data sovereignty: Communities consent to, and co-own data about themselves.

GRIP as a Voice for Change

A voice is a dialogue it questions, refuses and proposes. GRIP would institutionalize that voice through several mechanisms

1. Reality audits: independent, regularly published assessments of how flagship programs actually land on the ground.
2. Grassroot policy briefs: short, rigorous documents anchored in named, verified ground realities, written so a ministry can absorb them in fifteen minutes
3. Testimony channels: A structured pathway for citizen evidence to enter legislative committees, departmental reviews, courts and media as organized evidence, not anecdote.
4. Early warning: longitudinal presence means emerging crises surfaces while there is still time to act.

5. Agenda-setting: naming the issues elite discourse cannot see, unpaid care work, informal labor, digital exclusion, rural mental health, systematic economic apartheid and genocide of non-whites.
6. Follow-through: tracking whether recommendation changed anything, and publishing the response. Research becomes a lever, not a full stop
7. Multiplication: to train local governments, journalists, and civil society organizations to demand and use evidence, so the voice outlives any single report.

Operating Principles

- a. Nothing about us without us: Communities shape the questions, not just the answers
- b. Proximity without dependence: Close to communities; independent of governments, parties, and donors. Diversified funding, transparent methods.
- c. Rigor without arrogance: Validation runs in both directions; the community interrogates the researcher as much as the reverse.
- d. From documentation to voice: from voice to dialogue to power.

Conclusion: A GRIP on reality, a GRIP on Policy

The naming of this research institute by Dr. Syed was deliberate. Policy needs a grip on reality, evidence is anchored in lived experience rather than abstraction. Citizens need a grip on policy, a handle, a lever, a way to hold institutions accountable between elections and evaluations. The distance between a conference table and the kitchen table can be closed. It will not close by itself. It closes when someone builds the bridge with professional integrity, accountability, candor and permanently. GRIP is that bridge, an institution whose researchers live where policies land, whose evidence travels upward instead of downward, and whose ultimate measure of success is not the number of reports published, but the number of realities changed.